Aboard the Purple Elephant

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Aboard the Purple Elephant

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Adora has been at Camp Bright Moon for a few weeks now, after her big departure from her old camp, and she's helping Bow check out the camp bus. Now, she's going to take a short trip with him, still not sure about things but trying.

Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the work for more notes

“Left turn signal!” Bow shouted from where he stood behind the bus.

The light flicked on and off and Bow made a check on the list he held.

“Right turn signal!” Bow shouted again and watched as the left turn signal turned off and the right turn signal came on. He smiled as he checked off the list and then walked up along the bus, its purple paint job a bit scruffy but clean. He had no idea who’d named it the Purple Elephant but he loved it. He’d spent a lot of time in it over the years at Camp Bright Moon and now he was in charge of it. He patted its side affectionately as he got up to the driver’s side window and Adora leaned out from where she sat in the driver’s seat.

“What else?” Adora said.

“That’s everything,” he said as he signed the checklist and then handed it up to Adora. “Could you tuck this into the folder that’s next to the driver’s seat, please?”

Adora took it and got it filed away as Bow came around the side with the door. Adora had been at the camp for several weeks now after her drama-filled departure with her now girlfriend Catra from Camp Horde for the Lord across the river from Camp Bright Moon. Bow found her a bit intense sometimes but he had to admit, questioning everything you ever knew in life probably had a way of doing that. The camp she came from had been a church camp

and she'd been in heavy denial about herself so the last few weeks were definitely something like she'd never known.

Bow went up the stairs as Adora got up and moved out of his way as he got settled into the driver seat of the bus. He was scheduled to pick up a group of campers from a rope course downriver and he checked the mirrors as Adora started down the steps

"Want to come along?" Bow said as he adjusted a mirror.

"Uh, are you sure it's alright?" Adora said. "Shouldn't I ask Mr. Micah?"

Bow shook his head as he said, "You know he's said to call him Micah and I think it's fine if you come along. Did you have something to do?"

"Well, no. I'm caught up on the office stuff I was doing for Mermista but I figured there would be something else I could make myself helpful with," Adora said.

"I have a job for you then. You can keep me company on the drive," Bow said with a smile as he grabbed a radio off his belt. "I'll let Glimmer know you're with me if you want to go."

Adora waffled for a moment and then sat down in the front row seat by the door. Bow gave a thumbs up and shut the door before

calling Glimmer and letting her know what was going on. Then he shifted the bus into gear and reached up to turn on an old radio strapped up beside the driver's seat. Music started playing but otherwise it was quiet in the bus as they drove down the road. Bow could see Adora looking ahead as he drove and could tell she was thinking. Then a bouncy song came on and Bow grinned as he turned it up a little.

"I love this song," Bow said when he saw Adora's eyes flick towards him. "What do you think?"

"I've, uh, never heard it," Adora said, blushing a little. Bow twisted his face a little in confusion. It was a hit and had been all over the place that summer.

"Kind of surprised," Bow said with a smile. "I swear I've heard it in my sleep sometimes."

Adora was silent and Bow could feel the awkwardness.

"Adora, you alright? What is it?" Bow said.

"I don't listen to this kind of music," Adora said.

"Dance music?" Bow said, not understanding.

Adora looked away and muttered something Bow couldn’t understand. Bow turned the music down as he said, “I'm sorry, I couldn’t hear you.”

Adora looked at him, her face nervous as she said, “I said secular music.”

It took a second for Bow to understand and then he nodded.

“I’m sorry. Do you want me to change it or turn it off?” Bow said.

Adora shook her head as she said, “No, it’s OK. It’s just, uh, I guess it’s just reminding me that things have changed, that I’m different.”

Bow glanced over her at her real quick before putting his eyes back on the road.

“Adora, you’re still you. You’re just more truly you now,” Bow said. “I know that more than most.”

Adora looked at him and it was her turn to take a moment to understand. When she did, she blushed hard in embarrassment as she said, “I guess so.”

Bow laughed as he said, “Is me being trans really that uncomfortable?”

Adora started to say no, of course not, when she stopped herself.

“Maybe not uncomfortable but yeah, it’s different to me. I’m sorry, I really don’t want to be rude or a jerk to you about it,” Adora said.

“The first night we met, when you found out,” Bow said, referring to running into her when she was still at the other camp and trying to find a lost horse, “you were kind of a jerk but you know, you didn’t run screaming and you didn’t immediately start preaching at me. You’ve never really brought it up since.”

Adora looked out the window as she said, “It’s not something I really think about to be honest.”

Bow nodded and then was quiet as he jostled over a rough spot of road. The song ended and a DJ announced the radio station call sign before telling them that they were listening to the station with the greatest hits. It then went on to announce they’d be hit with back to back tunes to jam to on that summer afternoon right after these commercials. Bow turned the radio down until it was just faint background noise as a car lot commercial came on and said, “Listen, if you have questions, ask.”

“I don’t want to be rude,” Adora said quickly.

"Just give a little thought before you speak, just like you did that night," Bow said. "On my part, I'll assume you're trying to ask from a good spot but I've got no problem telling you if you're being rude. I'll say this though, don't ask about surgeries. It's really rude."

Adora nodded as she said, "Oh, gotcha. Ummm… so are you changing your name?"

"I already did," Bow said. "My dads are going to help me change it and the gender marker on my birth certificate this fall. Before you ask, I'm not telling you my dead name."

"Dead name?" Adora said. "Do you mean your… um, birth name?"

"You were going to say real name weren't you?" Bow said with a chuckle. Adora nodded as she blushed and Bow went on. "See, that's what I mean by I know you're trying, because you thought and caught yourself mid-sentence there and changed course, but yeah, don't ever ask that and definitely don't call it my real name. It's not like a camp nickname."

Adora nodded as she went back to staring out the window as they went down the road. Bow looked at her but let her be and turned the music up a little bit again as the commercials came to an end. Then Bow had an idea.

“Hey, what kind of music do you listen to?” Bow said. “Just curious.”

Adora shrugged as she looked back at Bow and said, “I like praise and worship stuff, especially the older hymns.”

“Oh, like, ‘When I went down to the river to pray, studying about that good ol’ way’,” Bow suddenly sang.

Adora’s eyes widened in surprise and she smiled as she said, “Yes! You know that!?”

Bow laughed as he said, “It’s in a movie I like but yeah, I do. OK, if that surprised you, this is going to blow your mind. What if I said, Sir Reginald’s Silly Slapstick Sing-A-Long Songs?”

Adora was shaking her head in disbelief as she said, “You know about the Fruit Fables show? With Robert the Radish and Orenthal the Onion?”

“Not really,” Bow said. “I mean, yes, I know what you’re talking about because I had a babysitter who’d play the songs for me when I was a kid and I know about the characters but I never watched the main cartoon. I loved the *Where is My Toothbrush?* song when I was young. Drove my dads crazy singing it constantly.”

Adora smiled as she said, “That was OK but I really loved *Orenthal’s Big Silk Scarf.* I used to sing it all the time as well.”

Bow was grinning at how animated Adora was and then watched as she seemed to deflate and sigh.

“Hey, you alright?” Bow said.

Adora shook her head as she said, “It just made me think about my mother.”

“I’m sorry,” Bow said.

“It’s not your fault,” Adora said. “It was my decision.”

Bow heard how tired she sounded and quietly said, “I can barely imagine how hard that must have been.”

Adora gave a sad smile and just nodded.

“Do you want to sing one of the songs?” Bow said after a moment of silence.

Adora shook her head as she said, “No. It’s neat that you know them though. Does Glimmer?”

Bow nodded as he said, “Just a few. I got us to sing a few at campfires a couple years back but she didn’t know them before I introduced them.”

They went quiet again. After a few minutes, Bow slowed and took the turn into the ropes course parking lot. Several other camp buses were pulled up in the dirt parking lot and Adora read a few of the names, not recognizing any, as Bow got the Purple Elephant parked and shut the engine off. The radio was suddenly loud in the quiet and Bow reached up to shut it off.

“We’re a little early,” Bow said, looking at the digital clock velcroed to the dash. “You helping me on the checklist sped it up, thank you.”

Adora nodded and started to open her mouth and then closed it.

“What do you want to ask me?” Bow said. “I can see it on your face.”

“How… how did you know you were…,” Adora said, not quite able to express what she was thinking.

“How did I know I was trans?” Bow said gently. Adora nodded. “I’ll turn it around on you. How do you know you're a woman?”

Bow had asked people that question before and had got responses ranging from bafflement to hostility. Adora started to answer immediately and then stopped for a second before finally answering.

“I was going to say I have, um, you know,” Adora said, her eyes flicking down and then up to Bow before she looked off in embarrassment before going on. “It’s not that simple though is it?”

Bow shrugged as he said, “No, it’s not and that’s not really an answer there. Do you want me to let you off the hook?”

Adora started to say yes and then squared up her shoulders as she said, “No, this is important to you. You’ve certainly listened to me go on about religious stuff enough lately.” Bow sat back in the seat and waited as Adora took another moment. “I guess I’d say it’s because it’s what I feel like.”

Bow nodded as he said, “That’s how I knew because my assigned gender at birth never felt right to me, whereas yours does to you. I didn’t hate my body or anything, the gender just didn’t feel right but not in a way I could put my finger on. Then I was looking in the mirror one day at home a few years ago, fiddling with my hair, trying to get it to look a certain way and then I stopped and stared at myself. My hair was pulled back and you couldn’t tell it was long and I said, ‘Him,’ to my reflection.”

Bow went quiet as he thought of that moment. He was giving the short version. There'd been a lot building up to that moment but that had been the moment he'd finally voiced it. He smiled as he remembered that moment and tears came to his eyes that he wiped away.

"I'm so sorry!" Adora said and Bow snapped out of his reverie. "I didn't mean to make you cry!"

Bow laughed as he said, "This isn't you. I was just thinking of that moment. It's a strong memory but a good one because I made a big breakthrough understanding who I was. I think you can relate."

Adora gave a shy smile as she looked down and thought about when she'd finally admitted to herself that she was a lesbian as she said, "Yeah, I guess I can."

Bow almost told her about how his dads were supportive, although his dad George had been a bit confused. He remembered the two of them taking him that very afternoon though to their barber so he could get his hair cut just like he wanted. Then he thought of Adora and her broken relationship with her mother and stopped himself.

"That's the basics of it, I guess," Bow said. "It was always there but I didn't understand at first. Now, I do. I feel so much happier than I used to and I've got good friends who support me."

Adora nodded as she said, "You do have good friends."

"Yep, I do have good friends and I'm glad you're one of them," Bow said and Adora looked up at him.

"We are friends, aren't we?" Adora said.

"I helped you find a lost horse and yanked you and your girlfriend out of a raging river," Bow said. "You help me keep this old bus up and running and even though you say that *Where is My Toothbrush?* is only OK, I still think of you as my friend."

Adora laughed before settling back into the seat. She could see the kids getting gathered up by their counselor and knew they'd be leaving soon.

"Psalm 139 talks about God knowing us before our birth and there's a bit that says we are fearfully and wonderfully made," Adora said. Bow looked at her, waiting to see what she was going to say. "If God knew you before birth and made you then he must have made you as you are now. I still don't think I understand fully but that's fine, God does, and I'm glad he made my friend wonderfully and you were able to figure it out."

Bow suddenly found tears in his eyes again as he stood up and opened his arms.

“You don’t get to say that and not get a hug,” Bow said.

Adora stood up and hugged him tightly before the two walked outside to greet the campers. As the campers started towards the bus, Adora said, “Bow, do you have a camp nickname?”

Bow nodded as he said, “I do. It’s Arrow Boy.”

Adora wasn’t sure why she did but it struck her just right and she started laughing as Bow grinned before laughing right along with her.

End Notes

So these were supposed to be fluffy but I swear, that never works for me. I had things I have to say. Something I see a lot of people say about being in a controlling situation like a church such as Adora was in was why don't they just leave? I tried to address part of that here. Because it's terrifying, especially if it's all you've ever known. Everything from how you relate to people, to how you think of the world, and even right down to what pop culture you're familiar with is different. You fill like you don't fit in, like the ultimate outsider. It's difficult.

As to the trans stuff, I came out as nonbinary a few months back. The amount of times I've had to tell people what Bow did with the, "I'm going to assume you're doing this in good faith," thing was pretty constant there for a while and I didn't even change my name. It does help the people I was having these talks with were actually asking in good faith because while it's easy sometimes to think people just know gender stuff, most really don't and I don't mind trying to explain.

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